Website won't load: DNS and proxy troubleshooting

Article KB0010028 | Owner: Network Support | Subcategory: Website / DNS / proxy | Applies to: Windows 11 23H2/24H2 (Dell Latitude, Lenovo ThinkPad, HP EliteBook), macOS 14/15 (MacBook Pro/Air), Corporate laptops managed by Microsoft Intune, Remote workers using GlobalProtect VPN, Any device connected to ACME-Corp Wi-Fi or wired LAN

Summary

This article guides users and service-desk agents through troubleshooting when internal or external websites fail to load due to DNS or proxy issues. It covers common symptoms, likely causes, a user self-help flow to flush DNS, renew IP and check proxy settings, and a detailed agent procedure for deeper diagnostics and escalation.

Symptoms

- Browser shows DNS_PROBE_FINISHED_NXDOMAIN or ERR_NAME_NOT_RESOLVED
- Page fails to load with Proxy server is refusing connections
- Error Unable to connect to the proxy server appears in Chrome/Edge
- Site cannot be reached while other sites work
- Intermittent timeout or This site cant be reached after connecting to VPN

Common causes

- Stale or corrupted DNS resolver cache on the client
- Manual proxy configuration pointing to a non existent or misconfigured proxy server
- Split tunnel VPN causing DNS queries to go to public resolvers instead of internal DNS
- Web filter (Secure Web Gateway) blocking the URL by category
- DHCP/DNS server handing out incorrect DNS addresses or experiencing an outage

Initial Checks

Before diving into fixes verify that the problem is isolated to a specific site or affects multiple sites. Ask the user to try loading a known internal page such as the company intranet home page and an external site like www.google.com. If only one site fails note the exact URL and any error message displayed. If all sites fail the issue is likely DNS or proxy related and you can proceed with the troubleshooting steps below.

Self Help Procedure for Users

Follow these steps to clear common DNS and proxy problems on your Acme Global laptop. They are safe to run without admin rights and usually restore browsing within a few minutes.

1. Test the site again. If it still fails try accessing the site by its IP address if known or use a different browser such as Firefox to rule out browser specific caching.

Service Desk Agent Troubleshooting

When the user reports that the self help steps did not resolve the issue follow this structured procedure to isolate DNS or proxy problems and determine whether escalation is needed.

1. Review web filter logs if accessible for the blocked URL. Search the Secure Web Gateway logs for the user IP or username and the target domain. If a category block is shown note the category and prepare an unblock request.

Verification and Closure

After applying a fix confirm that browsing is restored and document the resolution steps in the ticket. Ask the user to test the originally problematic site and at least two other sites one internal one external. If successful close the ticket with a summary of the action taken e.g. Flushed DNS cache and renewed IP proxy setting corrected site now loads. If the issue persists after all steps move to escalation as described above.

When to escalate

Escalate to Network Support when DNS resolution fails for internal names while public DNS works providing the captured nslookup traceroute output. Escalate to Identity Access Management if proxy settings are incorrect or a manual proxy keeps reappearing include GPO or Intune policy details. Escalate to Security Operations if the web filter is blocking the site attach log evidence and request a category review or temporary whitelist. In all cases include the user

name device hostname timestamp and a summary of steps already taken.

Keywords: DNS, proxy, website not loading, DNS_PROBE_FINISHED, ERR_NAME_NOT_RESOLVED, flush DNS, renew IP, manual proxy, web filter, split tunnel, GlobalProtect, nslookup, ipconfig